justification for the sort of sweeping allegations of funding and collaborating with the ULFA'. The release further clarified that its Guwahati office had no wherewithal to check if a person taking medical assistance was a member of ULFA or any other banned outfit.

But the statements could not fully counter all the allegations of the Assam police. The police had released evidence of Deka being given special treatment by the group, which had gone out of its way and violated its own guidelines. The Medical Aid scheme only provided for the treatment of heart-, cancer- and eyesight-related ailments. Further, the approved hospitals for the scheme were the B.M. Birla Hospital, Calcutta, the Tata Memorial Hospital, Mumbai, and Shankara Nethralaya, Chennai. Jaslok Hospital was not included in the panel.

An interview given by Baruah, however, brought some much-welcome relief for the Tatas. He told a newsmagazine, 'She [Deka] needed special care, which was not available in our remote bases. And we obviously had to conceal her identity because if someone in Tata Tea knew who she was, there was always a possibility of the information being leaked.' But the Assam police believed that at least two Tata Tea officials were aware of Deka's actual identity.

The then inspector general of police (IGP), Special Branch, N. Ramachandran, who was also head of the state intelligence, confirms that the police had intelligence information that some of the Tata Tea officials at the lower levels had close contacts with militant leaders. He also remembers that Gogoi was cited in the intelligence reports not only in connection with Pranati's treatment, but also because of his independent links with ULFA. Ramachandran, however, added that often, lower functionaries would act on their own without the knowledge or consent of the higher-ups in the group. He said that it was no different in this case.

While this might have been the reality, the Assam government relentlessly attacked the Tata Group for its alleged collusion with ULFA. Even in the face of this, Ratan continued to undertake welfare schemes in the state. If anything, he did so with more vigour and determination, reiterating the group's stance that it had never supported any form of militancy in any manner and had instead only focused on implementing welfare programmes.

The 12 September press release also gave the company's version of the Pranati Deka episode. It reiterated that the company had thwarted all